



# Reflections on the Life of the Spirit

Ruhi Institute



Book 1



# Prayer

## Purpose

To reflect on the significance of prayer and  
to reinforce the habit of praying regularly



## SECTION 1

The courses of the Ruhi Institute are intended to help participants walk a path of service. We walk this path impelled by a twofold sense of purpose—to grow spiritually and intellectually and to contribute to the transformation of society. These two aspects of our purpose are inseparable from each other. Bahá'u'lláh exhorts us in one passage:

**“Do not busy yourselves in your own concerns; let your thoughts be fixed upon that which will rehabilitate the fortunes of mankind and sanctify the hearts and souls of men.”<sup>1</sup>**

In another passage, He makes clear:

**“ . . . the purpose for which mortal men have, from utter nothingness, stepped into the realm of being, is that they may work for the betterment of the world and live together in concord and harmony.”<sup>2</sup>**

In relation to our inner condition, He declares:

**“A pure heart is as a mirror; cleanse it with the burnish of love and severance from all save God, that the true sun may shine therein and the eternal morning dawn.”<sup>3</sup>**

And ‘Abdu’l-Bahá tells us:

**“Your hearts must be pure and your intentions sincere in order that you may become recipients of the divine bestowals.”<sup>4</sup>**

1. What should be the focus of our thoughts and concerns? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
2. For what purpose have we stepped from utter nothingness into the realm of being?  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. With what should we cleanse the mirror of our heart? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
4. What are some of the conditions that attract divine bestowals? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

5. Are any of the following true?

- First you should take care of yourself, and then you can take care of others.
- If you are always helping others, you will end up losing sight of your own goals.
- You are your closest friend.
- What is most important is finding out what makes you happy.
- Follow your dreams, and they will lead you to happiness.
- As long as you are not hurting anyone else, it does not matter what you do.
- It is all right for your motives to be selfish, as long as you do some good.

## SECTION 2

A conviction central to our twofold purpose is that we have all been created noble. Bahá'u'lláh says:

**“O Son of Spirit! I created thee rich, why dost thou bring thyself down to poverty? Noble I made thee, wherewith dost thou abase thyself? Out of the essence of knowledge I gave thee being, why seekest thou enlightenment from anyone beside Me? Out of the clay of love I molded thee, how dost thou busy thyself with another? Turn thy sight unto thyself, that thou mayest find Me standing within thee, mighty, powerful and self-subsisting.”<sup>5</sup>**

Filling in the blanks below will help you reflect on this passage.

“O Son of Spirit! I created thee \_\_\_\_\_, why dost thou bring thyself \_\_\_\_\_ to \_\_\_\_\_? \_\_\_\_\_ I \_\_\_\_\_ thee, wherewith dost thou \_\_\_\_\_ thyself? Out of the \_\_\_\_\_ of \_\_\_\_\_ I gave thee being, why \_\_\_\_\_ thou \_\_\_\_\_ from anyone beside \_\_\_\_\_? Out of the clay of \_\_\_\_\_ I \_\_\_\_\_ thee, how dost thou \_\_\_\_\_ thyself with \_\_\_\_\_? Turn thy \_\_\_\_\_ unto \_\_\_\_\_, that thou mayest find \_\_\_\_\_ standing within thee, \_\_\_\_\_, \_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_.”

To be true to the nobility of our souls, we must turn to the Source of our being and seek enlightenment from Him. One of the most compelling ways to achieve this is through prayer. Shoghi Effendi, Guardian of the Faith, tells us that its chief goal is “the development of the individual and society, through the acquisition of spiritual virtues and powers. It is the soul of man that has first to be fed. And this spiritual nourishment prayer can best provide.”<sup>6</sup>

## SECTION 3

God is the All-Knowing, the All-Wise. He created us and knows what is in our hearts and what is best for us. He does not need our prayers. Then why do we pray?

‘Abdu’l-Bahá states:

**“In the highest prayer, men pray only for the love of God, not because they fear Him or hell, or hope for bounty or heaven. . . . When a man falls in love with a human being, it is impossible for him to keep from mentioning the name of his beloved. How much more difficult is it to keep from mentioning the Name of God when one has come to love Him. . . . The spiritual man finds no delight in anything save in commemoration of God.”<sup>7</sup>**

And, in response to a query, He explains:

**“If one friend loves another, is it not natural that he should wish to say so? Though he knows that that friend is aware of his love, does he still not wish to tell him of it? . . . It is true that God knows the wishes of all hearts; but the impulse to pray is a natural one, springing from man’s love to God.”<sup>8</sup>**

1. Complete the following sentences:
  - a. In the \_\_\_\_\_ prayer, we \_\_\_\_\_ only for the \_\_\_\_\_ of God, not because we fear Him or \_\_\_\_\_, or hope for \_\_\_\_\_ or \_\_\_\_\_.
  - b. When we fall in \_\_\_\_\_ with another human being, it is \_\_\_\_\_ for us to keep from mentioning the \_\_\_\_\_ of our \_\_\_\_\_. How much more \_\_\_\_\_ is it to keep from \_\_\_\_\_ the Name of \_\_\_\_\_ when one has come to \_\_\_\_\_ Him.
  - c. A spiritual person finds \_\_\_\_\_ in nothing other than in \_\_\_\_\_ of God.
2. Why do we pray? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. What does the phrase “commemoration of God” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
4. What is the most fervent wish of a person who loves another? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
5. What does the impulse to pray spring from? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

## SECTION 4

In a prayer revealed by Bahá'u'lláh, we read:

**“I beseech Thee . . . to make of my prayer a fire that will burn away the veils which have shut me out from Thy beauty, and a light that will lead me unto the ocean of Thy Presence.”<sup>9</sup>**

We ask of God in that same prayer:

**“Make my prayer, O my Lord, a fountain of living waters whereby I may live as long as Thy sovereignty endureth, and may make mention of Thee in every world of Thy worlds.”<sup>10</sup>**

1. In what sense can prayer be like a fire? What does it consume? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
2. Mention some veils that shut us out from God: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Can prayer be like a light? Where does it lead us? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
4. Can prayer be like a fountain of living waters? What does it bestow upon our souls?  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

## SECTION 5

Read and reflect on the following words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá:

**“There is nothing sweeter in the world of existence than prayer. Man must live in a state of prayer. The most blessed condition is the condition of prayer and supplication. Prayer is conversation with God. The greatest attainment or the sweetest state is none other than conversation with God. It creates spirituality, creates mindfulness and celestial feelings, begets new attractions of the Kingdom and engenders the susceptibilities of the higher intelligence.”<sup>11</sup>**

1. What is the sweetest state in the world of existence? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

2. What does the phrase “state of prayer” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Mention some of the attributes created by prayer: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
4. Review the quotations you have studied in these few sections and write five phrases on the nature of prayer.
  - Prayer is \_\_\_\_\_
  - Prayer is \_\_\_\_\_
  - Prayer is \_\_\_\_\_
  - Prayer is \_\_\_\_\_
  - Prayer is \_\_\_\_\_

## SECTION 6

Read the following words of Bahá'u'lláh and meditate on them:

**“Intone, O My servant, the verses of God that have been received by thee, as intoned by them who have drawn nigh unto Him, that the sweetness of thy melody may kindle thine own soul, and attract the hearts of all men. Whoso reciteth, in the privacy of his chamber, the verses revealed by God, the scattering angels of the Almighty shall scatter abroad the fragrance of the words uttered by his mouth, and shall cause the heart of every righteous man to throb. Though he may, at first, remain unaware of its effect, yet the virtue of the grace vouchsafed unto him must needs sooner or later exercise its influence upon his soul. Thus have the mysteries of the Revelation of God been decreed by virtue of the Will of Him Who is the Source of power and wisdom.”<sup>12</sup>**

1. What does the word “intone” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
2. How should we intone the verses of God? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_



3. What does the word “recite” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
4. What does the word “scatter” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
5. What effect will the sweetness of our melody have on our own souls? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
6. What effect will the sweetness of our melody have on the hearts of others? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

## SECTION 7

You may wish to memorize the following two passages from a prayer revealed by Bahá'u'lláh:

**“O God, my God! Look not upon my hopes and my doings, nay rather look upon Thy will that hath encompassed the heavens and the earth. By Thy Most Great Name, O Thou Lord of all nations! I have desired only what Thou didst desire, and love only what Thou dost love.”<sup>13</sup>**

**“Too high art Thou for the praise of those who are nigh unto Thee to ascend unto the heaven of Thy nearness, or for the birds of the hearts of them who are devoted to Thee to attain to the door of Thy gate. I testify that Thou hast been sanctified above all attributes and holy above all names. No God is there but Thee, the Most Exalted, the All-Glorious.”<sup>14</sup>**

## SECTION 8

‘Abdu’l-Bahá states:

**“It behooveth the servant to pray to and seek assistance from God, and to supplicate and implore His aid. Such becometh the rank of servitude, and the Lord will decree whatsoever He desireth, in accordance with His consummate wisdom.”<sup>15</sup>**

And He explains:

**“Spirit has influence; prayer has spiritual effect. Therefore, we pray, ‘O God! Heal this sick one!’ Perchance God will answer. Does it matter who prays? God will answer the prayer of every servant if that prayer is urgent. His mercy is vast, illimitable. He answers the prayers of all His servants. He answers the prayer of this plant. The plant prays potentially, ‘O God! Send me rain!’ God answers the prayer, and the plant grows. God will answer anyone.”<sup>16</sup>**

It is natural that in our prayers we would ask God to fulfill our needs. Thus we pray for our health and the health of our loved ones, we pray for the spiritual and material progress of our families, and we pray for guidance. We ask for strength, for faith, and for confirmation in the path of service. In praying to God, we should, of course, remember that our goal in life is to align our will with His Will. Therefore, we must pray for His Will to be done and be ready to submit to it. If you commit the following words of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá to memory, they will serve as a source of joy and assurance to you at all times:

**“O thou who art turning thy face towards God! Close thine eyes to all things else, and open them to the realm of the All-Glorious. Ask whatsoever thou wishest of Him alone; seek whatsoever thou seekest from Him alone. With a look He granteth a hundred thousand hopes, with a glance He healeth a hundred thousand incurable ills, with a nod He layeth balm on every wound, with a glimpse He freeth the hearts from the shackles of grief. He doeth as He doeth, and what recourse have we? He carrieth out His Will, He ordaineth what He pleaseth. Then better for thee to bow down thy head in submission, and put thy trust in the All-Merciful Lord.”<sup>17</sup>**

## SECTION 9

From everything we have studied up to now, it is clear that turning to God in prayer is a vital requirement of a spiritual life. How especially sweet it is to pray to God soon after waking in the morning and at night before going to sleep. The time we spend praying each day and the number of prayers we say depend on our needs and our spiritual thirst. On every occasion, we are able to choose from the many prayers revealed by Bahá’u’lláh, the Báb, and ‘Abdu’l-Bahá. Bahá’u’lláh has also revealed, however, three daily obligatory prayers. Shoghi Effendi says:

**“The daily obligatory prayers are three in number. The shortest one consists of a single verse which has to be recited once every twenty-four hours at midday. The medium, which begins with the words, ‘The Lord is witness that there is none other God but He,’ has to be recited three times a day, in the morning, at noon and in the evening. This prayer is accompanied by certain physical acts and gestures. The long prayer, which is the most elaborate of the three, has to be recited only once in every twenty-four hours, and at any time one feels inclined to do so.**

**“The believer is entirely free to choose any one of these three prayers, but is under the obligation of reciting one of them, and in accordance with any specific directions with which it may be accompanied.”<sup>18</sup>**

And he continues:

**“These daily obligatory prayers, together with a few other specific ones, such as the Healing Prayer, the Tablet of Ahmad, have been invested by Bahá’u’lláh with a special potency and significance, and should therefore be accepted as such and be recited by the believers with unquestioning faith and confidence, that through them they may enter into a much closer communion with God, and identify themselves more fully with His laws and precepts.”<sup>19</sup>**

The three obligatory prayers revealed by Bahá'u'lláh are said individually. The kind of congregational prayer where a daily obligatory prayer is recited in a group according to a certain ritual does not exist in the Bahá'í Faith. The Prayer for the Dead is the only congregational prayer prescribed by Bahá'í law. It is to be recited before interment by one of those present, while the remainder of the group stands in silence.

1. What does the word “obligatory” mean? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
2. How many daily obligatory prayers has Bahá'u'lláh revealed? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Should we recite all three prayers every day? \_\_\_\_\_
4. If we choose to say the Long Obligatory Prayer, how many times should we recite it each day? \_\_\_\_\_
5. How many times, if we choose to say the Medium Obligatory Prayer? \_\_\_\_\_
6. How many times, if we choose the Short Obligatory Prayer? \_\_\_\_\_
7. Mention some of the prayers which have a special power: \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
8. Memorize, if you have not already done so, the Short Obligatory Prayer:

**“I bear witness, O my God, that Thou hast created me to know Thee and to worship Thee. I testify, at this moment, to my powerlessness and to Thy might, to my poverty and to Thy wealth.**

**“There is none other God but Thee, the Help in Peril, the Self-Subsisting.”<sup>20</sup>**

9. To what do we attest in this prayer? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

## SECTION 10

We should remember that, in addition to the blessings we receive from obeying the law of obligatory prayer and the nourishment we obtain from saying other prayers individually, our souls are uplifted when we hear prayers being recited in gatherings, large or small. Bahá'u'lláh tells us:

**“Gather ye together with the utmost joy and fellowship and recite the verses revealed by the merciful Lord. By so doing the doors of true knowledge will be opened to your inner beings, and ye will then feel your souls endowed with steadfastness and your hearts filled with radiant joy.”<sup>21</sup>**

We all derive great joy from the knowledge that, around the world, devotional gatherings in which friends and neighbors come together to commune with God are multiplying by the thousands. The Universal House of Justice writes:

**“Devotional meetings are occasions where any soul may enter, inhale the heavenly fragrances, experience the sweetness of prayer, meditate upon the Creative Word, be transported on the wings of the spirit, and commune with the one Beloved. Feelings of fellowship and common cause are generated, particularly in the spiritually heightened conversations that naturally occur at such times and through which the ‘city of the human heart’ may be opened.”<sup>22</sup>**

When we feel moved to pray, we wait quietly for a moment in order to cleanse our minds of the things of this world. While praying, we keep our thoughts centered on God. After we have recited prayers, we remain silent for some time and do not move abruptly into another activity. The same is true when we listen to prayers offered by others in a gathering. On such occasions, we maintain a prayerful attitude and follow the words closely, as though we were the one reciting them.

1. With what spirit should we gather together when reciting the verses of God? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
2. What will be the effect of our gathering together to recite the verses of God? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
3. Devotional meetings are occasions where any soul can  
— \_\_\_\_\_ ,  
— \_\_\_\_\_ ,  
— \_\_\_\_\_ ,  
— \_\_\_\_\_ ,  
— \_\_\_\_\_ , and  
— \_\_\_\_\_ .
4. What feelings are generated at devotional meetings? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_
5. What is the effect of the spiritually heightened conversations that naturally occur at devotional meetings? \_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_

6. Write a few words about the respectful attitude we should show when praying, whether alone or in a gathering.

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## SECTION 11

The first unit of this book focused on the habit of reading passages from the Writings every day and pondering their meaning. You have reflected here on the significance of prayer and have, as a result, reinforced the habit of praying daily. The previous section brought to your attention the importance of community worship. All that you have studied so far has prepared you to undertake, if you wish, a first act on the path of service: hosting a devotional meeting.

As an initial step, you may want to memorize several prayers and find an opportunity to share them with a few friends. At the same time, you could ensure that you attend at least one devotional meeting in your community and are counted among its enthusiastic supporters. Eventually, then, you may decide to host a devotional meeting yourself, inviting your friends, family members, and neighbors to gather regularly for prayer and fellowship. It is not uncommon for two or three participants of this course to start such a devotional meeting together.

As you can imagine, there are no formulas for how a devotional meeting is to be organized. But it is clearly a gathering of friends in which prayers are offered, passages from the Writings are read, and uplifting conversations take place—all in a markedly spiritual atmosphere. Can you say a few words about each of the following ideas, in the context of hosting a devotional meeting?

Extending warm and loving invitations: \_\_\_\_\_

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Creating a welcoming environment: \_\_\_\_\_

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Maintaining an atmosphere of reverence: \_\_\_\_\_

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Promoting joyful fellowship: \_\_\_\_\_

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Encouraging spiritually uplifting conversation: \_\_\_\_\_

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